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IRFAN HABIB, HISTORIAN



their behalf and trigger-happy police often violating their rights as citizens. “We don't have a leader. The community is not really united enough and most are scared to make a statement against this rather insensitive and unfair branding of all Muslims as terrorists,” says Akhtar Ali, national selector and former Davis Cup player.

Many argue that when police indiscriminately round up Muslims, they are walking into the hands of fundamentalists. Any fundamentalist group, of any religion, benefits when their community feels besieged. “The communal stereotyping of Muslim minorities only alienates them and weakens the fight against terrorism. That is precisely what the RSS-BJP is doing today,” says Professor Inayat Zaidi, the president of

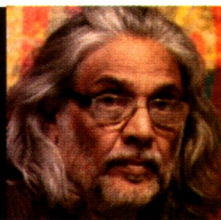
very few in numbers and it is ambitious to think that their voices will be heard.”

These issues, many feel, cannot be addressed by separate Muslim activity but by ensuring space for moderate voices in mainstream politics. “An overwhelming majority of Muslims believe in liberal values. Every faith has delivered its quota of terrorists. The Nagas who challenged Indian unity were Christians. The sister-regions of the North-east gave us Hindu terrorists. Sikhs rose in Punjab, and Muslims in Kashmir. The overwhelming majority of Naxalites are Hindus,” says noted journalist M.J. Akbar. “Anger which used to be directed through democratic framework has now found an outlet which is extremist. Indian Muslims should stand up against the extremist elements,” he asks.

He blames the present political leadership for its failure to the current despair. “Indian Muslims believe that if they had not mobilised to an unprecedented degree, the Congress would

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MUZAFFAR ALI, FILMMAKER



Jamia Millia Islamia University Teachers' Forum.

Others argue that the media is not doing enough to have the liberal voice heard. Muslims across the country may be victims of fatwa fatigue, but the media finds impressive soundbytes in fatwas on everything from fairness creams to family planning. “There are attempts made by Muslim artists and artisans to project the beauty of a composite culture but media interest lies elsewhere,” says filmmaker Muzaffar Ali. Some say the lack of liberal voice is part of larger crisis affecting the community. “The separate identity gets strengthened when they are alienated from the mainstream,” says historian Irfan Habib, adding: “The liberal elite establishment and success stories within the community are so minuscule that it is quite natural that they don't get heard. The academicians and lawyers are

never have got enough seats in the last general elections to cobble together a coalition. Indian Muslims claim a sort of ownership of the UPA regime. Why have Manmohan Singh and Sonia Gandhi been unable to prevent a spurt of despair within the community?” Former Congress leader Arif Mohammed Khan agrees: “The moderates are fighting both clergy and political establishment. The political parties are interested in patronising moderates without captive votebanks. The Congress dropped me like a hot potato when it found pressure of clergy was building after the Shah Bano case.

The truth is that politicians will patronise only the Maulana Madanis and Imam Bukharis, who have captive votebanks. Unless parties, like the Congress which swears by secularism, ensure that moderates are inducted in its leadership, the moderate majority will continue to be trapped between extremists in the community and a political establishment refusing to accommodate saner voices. ■

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AKHTAR ALI, FORMER DAVIS CUP PLAYER

